

CHRISTIANITY AND THE ABOLITION OF SLAVERY

*A chronological history of scripture, conscience, complicity, resistance, and
emancipation*



AN ILLUSTRATED-BY-WORDS HISTORICAL READER

*“Between the Christianity of this land, and the Christianity of Christ, I
recognize the widest possible difference.”*

- Frederick Douglass, Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass (1845)

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About this history

This book tells two histories at once. The first is the long history of Christian participation in slavery: biblical accommodation, ecclesiastical ownership, missionary compromise, papal and royal authorization, racial theology, and churches that split rather than abandon slaveholding. The second is the history of Christians who learned to name slavery as sin and organized to destroy it: enslaved and formerly enslaved believers, Black congregations, Quakers, evangelicals, women preachers, pamphleteers, missionaries, rebels, politicians, conductors on the Underground Railroad, soldiers, and reformers. The two histories overlap. They cannot honestly be separated.

The focus is the abolition of Atlantic racial chattel slavery from the fifteenth through nineteenth centuries, with earlier Christian history included because later writers repeatedly appealed to it. The last chapters follow abolition beyond Britain and the United States and ask what survived after legal emancipation. Christianity was never the sole cause of abolition. Enslaved people's resistance, revolutions, Enlightenment natural-rights arguments, political economy, state rivalry, changing labor systems, and secular humanitarianism were indispensable. The distinctive question here is narrower: what did Christian belief, scripture, institutions, and communities contribute - for good and for evil - to the making and unmaking of slave systems?

Quotations are kept brief and are identified by author and work. Archaic spelling has occasionally been modernized for readability without changing meaning. The source notes combine primary texts with major historical scholarship and institutional collections. Because the word 'slavery' has described different systems, the narrative distinguishes ancient enslavement, medieval servitude, Atlantic racial chattel slavery, and modern forced labor rather than treating them as identical.

A thesis in five sentences

- The Bible contains both texts that slaveholders used to command obedience and themes that abolitionists used to proclaim equal creation, deliverance, neighbor-love, and judgment against oppression.
- For most of Christian history, churches moderated, spiritualized, or regulated slavery more often than they demanded its universal abolition.
- A decisive change came when dissenting Christians began to treat slaveholding itself - not merely cruelty within it - as a corporate sin requiring public repentance and political action.
- Black Christians were not supporting characters in a white humanitarian drama: they supplied testimony, theology, organization, resistance, and a definition of freedom broader than legal emancipation.
- Abolition exposed a permanent test for Christian ethics: whether inherited authority is allowed to silence the suffering neighbor, or is re-read through love, justice, and the equal dignity of persons.

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CHAPTER PROLOGUE

A Faith Divided Against Itself

ANCIENT WORLD TO THE AGE OF EMANCIPATION | How the same religion became a shelter for bondage and a language of liberation

On slave ships, captains read prayers. In plantation chapels, ministers preached obedience. In hidden cabins, enslaved people sang of Moses. At abolition meetings, speakers opened Bibles to Isaiah and Luke. Christianity did not enter the history of slavery as a single moral force. It entered as a contested world of texts, institutions, rituals, interests, and hopes.

The most dangerous historical sentence is often the simplest: 'Christianity abolished slavery.' It is dangerous because it is partly true and therefore easy to turn into a myth. Christian abolitionists created durable organizations, circulated testimony, made political coalitions, sustained fugitives, and changed the moral vocabulary of the Atlantic world. Yet Christians also baptized enslaved people without freeing them, owned human beings, wrote laws for slave societies, lent sacred authority to conquest, expelled antislavery dissenters, and produced elaborate biblical defenses of hereditary bondage. The history is not a march from gospel to freedom. It is a civil war within Christian moral imagination.

The question that finally destabilized Christian slaveholding was not only whether a master behaved kindly. It was whether one person could rightfully possess another. That shift sounds obvious now, but it was revolutionary. For centuries, many Christians understood slavery as an unfortunate consequence of war, debt, crime, birth, or sin - a social condition that charity might soften. Abolitionism declared the condition itself intolerable. It transformed private mercy into public obligation. Manumitting one's own captive was good; organizing to abolish the legal power of all masters was better. The new abolitionist conscience moved from almsgiving to law, from individual benevolence to collective repentance.

That transformation did not begin in European parliaments. Enslaved people had always resisted: by flight, work slowdowns, preserving family and culture, petitioning, litigation, sabotage, rebellion, military service, and the creation of independent religious worlds. Their actions forced Christian observers to confront the human beings whom plantation ideology reduced to property. Testimony - spoken, dictated, printed, sung, or embodied in escape - became one of abolitionism's most powerful forms. Olaudah Equiano's autobiography, Mary

Prince's narrative, Frederick Douglass's speeches, and the sermons of Black ministers turned abstraction into encounter.

The history also teaches a lesson about interpretation. Proslavery Christians often possessed the stronger proof texts: patriarchs held slaves; Israelite law regulated slavery; Paul told enslaved believers to obey masters; the letter to Philemon did not explicitly order emancipation. Abolitionists answered with a different method. They read individual commands inside the larger drama of creation, Exodus, incarnation, the Golden Rule, the unity of humanity in Christ, and God's judgment on oppressors. In other words, the conflict was not Bible against unbelief. It was one way of reading the Bible against another.

“Both read the same Bible, and pray to the same God; and each invokes His aid against the other.”

- Abraham Lincoln, Second Inaugural Address (1865)

Lincoln's sentence described the Civil War, but it also summarizes the preceding centuries. The central drama is not that Christians discovered a forgotten verse that solved slavery. It is that communities decided which voices in scripture governed the rest, whose suffering counted as evidence, and whether the church's inherited practices could be judged by its own highest claims. The abolitionist answer was costly: if the enslaved person truly bore God's image and was a neighbor for whom Christ died, then piety without emancipation was hypocrisy.

Chapter notes and source trail

1. Frederick Douglass, *Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass, an American Slave* (Boston, 1845), Appendix.
2. David Brion Davis, *The Problem of Slavery in Western Culture* (Cornell University Press, 1966); Seymour Drescher, *Abolition: A History of Slavery and Antislavery* (Cambridge University Press, 2009).
3. Manisha Sinha, *The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition* (Yale University Press, 2016), emphasizes enslaved and Black activism at the movement's center.
4. Mark A. Noll, *The Civil War as a Theological Crisis* (University of North Carolina Press, 2006).
5. Abraham Lincoln, Second Inaugural Address, March 4, 1865, Library of Congress / National Archives milestone collections.

CHAPTER 1

Scripture in a Slaveholding World

BIBLICAL WORLDS AND LATER INTERPRETATION | The texts that bound, the texts that freed, and the struggle over how to read

Abolitionists and slaveholders did not argue over whether the Bible mattered. They argued over what kind of book it was: a collection of social permissions frozen in time, or a drama whose deepest movement ran from bondage toward freedom.

Ancient slavery and the biblical record

The societies in which the Hebrew Bible and New Testament were written were slaveholding societies. Enslavement came through war, debt, punishment, piracy, exposure of infants, sale, and birth. Ancient slavery was not identical to the modern Atlantic system: it was not everywhere organized by a single racial color line, and some enslaved people occupied skilled or administrative positions. But the institution remained coercive. Enslaved people could be bought, sold, beaten, sexually exploited, separated from family, and denied control over their labor and movement. Saying that ancient slavery differed from plantation slavery must never become a way of making it benign.¹

The Hebrew scriptures contain both regulation and liberation. Israelite law permitted forms of servitude, including harsher rules for foreigners than for fellow Israelites. Yet the national story began with deliverance from Pharaoh. 'I am the Lord thy God, which have brought thee out ... of the house of bondage' stood at the entrance to covenant. The law condemned kidnapping a person for sale, periodically limited debt servitude among Israelites, required rest for servants, and imagined Jubilee as a proclamation of liberty. The prophets made worship answerable to justice: the fast God chose was to 'let the oppressed go free.' Abolitionists would later gather these fragments into a theology of exodus.²

The New Testament did not launch a legal campaign against slavery. Household codes instructed enslaved believers to obey masters, and Paul urged Christian masters toward justice and restraint. In Philemon, Paul returned Onesimus while asking that he be received 'not now as a servant, but above a servant, a brother beloved.' The letter could be read conservatively - Paul did not explicitly command

manumission - or radically: once master and enslaved person belonged to one body, ownership had become morally unstable. Galatians announced that in Christ there was 'neither bond nor free,' but churches disagreed over whether this spiritual equality must change civil status.³

The proslavery reading

Later defenders of slavery built a cumulative case. Noah's curse on Canaan was distorted into a racial prophecy, though the text neither names Africans nor authorizes Atlantic slavery. Abraham owned servants. Mosaic law regulated human property. Jesus never issued an explicit abolition decree. Paul sent Onesimus back and told servants to obey. From these premises, proslavery theologians argued that an institution recognized by patriarchs, law, apostles, and the silence of Christ could not be intrinsically sinful. The burden of their argument lay in isolated permissions and commands. Its hidden assumption was that a social practice described or regulated in scripture remained morally normative in a radically different world.⁴

The abolitionist reading

Abolitionists answered less by denying the difficult passages than by ranking them. Creation declared humanity made in God's image. Exodus revealed God's attention to the cry of captives. The prophets judged nations for violence and fraud. Jesus identified love of God with love of neighbor and announced good news to the poor and liberty to captives. The Golden Rule required Christians to imagine themselves under the auctioneer's hammer. The incarnation gave human flesh immeasurable worth. The cross identified God with the condemned and abused. Pentecost broke ethnic monopoly; the church gathered peoples into one body. If these claims governed Christian ethics, then hereditary ownership of persons could not survive merely because ancient law had regulated servitude.⁵

"Liberty is the right of every human creature, as soon as he breathes the vital air."

- John Wesley, *Thoughts upon Slavery* (1774)

This was a hermeneutical revolution. Slaveholders asked, 'Where is slavery forbidden by name?' Abolitionists asked, 'What happens when the enslaved person's full humanity becomes the controlling fact?' The second question expanded moral evidence beyond the page. Scars, family separation, sexual coercion, stolen wages, and the testimony of fugitives became commentary on scripture. A religion that commanded neighbor-love had to look at what ownership did to the neighbor.

Onesimus

first century

ENSLAVED CHRISTIAN
NAMED IN PHILEMON**CENTRAL IDEA**

His presence in the New Testament forced later Christians to decide whether spiritual kinship could coexist with legal mastery.

KEY WRITINGS / ACTIONS *Paul's Letter to Philemon; later Christian debates over return, brotherhood, and manumission*

Chapter notes and source trail

1. Jennifer A. Glancy, *Slavery in Early Christianity* (Oxford University Press, 2002); Kyle Harper, *Slavery in the Late Roman World, AD 275-425* (Cambridge University Press, 2011).
2. Exodus 20:2; Exodus 21:16; Leviticus 25; Deuteronomy 5:14-15; Isaiah 58:6. Biblical quotations follow the King James Version unless noted.
3. Philemon 15-16; Galatians 3:28; Ephesians 6:5-9; Colossians 3:22-4:1; 1 Timothy 6:1-2.
4. Stephen R. Haynes, *Noah's Curse: The Biblical Justification of American Slavery* (Oxford University Press, 2002).
5. John Coffey, *Exodus and Liberation: Deliverance Politics from John Calvin to Martin Luther King Jr.* (Oxford University Press, 2014); John Wesley, *Thoughts upon Slavery* (1774), Project Gutenberg edition.

CHAPTER 2

The Early Church

FIRST TO FIFTH CENTURIES | Brotherhood without abolition - and one startling exception

Early Christian congregations gathered enslaved and free people at one table. That was socially unsettling. It was not yet a program to abolish the legal institution that made some worshipers the property of others.

The Roman Empire's economy and household order were saturated with slavery. Christians could be enslaved, could own enslaved people, and could free them. Martyr stories remembered enslaved believers such as Blandina; church offices were sometimes occupied by former slaves; congregations raised funds to redeem captives. The Eucharist announced a body in which status did not determine access to grace. Yet surviving Christian writings usually treated slavery as part of the fallen social world, not as an institution the church must eradicate.¹

Pastoral reform rather than social abolition

Church teachers emphasized moral reciprocity. Masters would answer to a heavenly Master. Enslaved Christians should endure without hatred; masters should restrain anger, avoid sexual abuse, and recognize spiritual kinship. This could improve lives, encourage manumission, and create spaces of dignity. It could also stabilize slavery by promising equality in heaven while preserving hierarchy on earth. Augustine described slavery as a consequence of sin and contrary to humanity's original condition, yet he accepted it as part of the temporal order through which disorder was governed.²

The church's charitable practices reveal the ambiguity. Redeeming captives was praised as mercy, especially when Christians had been seized in war or raids. Manumission at churches and during holy festivals gave freedom a sacred setting. But the selective rescue of captives did not imply that all ownership was unjust. Christians often distinguished between lawful and unlawful enslavement, between insiders and outsiders, and between humane and cruel masters. The moral imagination remained focused on the virtue of the owner more than the right of the owned.

Gregory of Nyssa's impossible question

Around the 380s, Gregory of Nyssa preached on Ecclesiastes and interrupted the long accommodation with a direct attack on mastery itself. He mocked the idea that

money could purchase a person whom God had made ruler over the earth. The buyer might count coins, but could not price rational nature, freedom, or the image of God. Gregory's force came from changing the subject. He did not ask whether the master was kind. He asked how one image-bearer could claim ownership of another.³

“How many obols did you reckon the image of God to be worth?”

- Gregory of Nyssa, Homily 4 on Ecclesiastes (c. 380)

Gregory's sermon is one of the clearest surviving condemnations of slaveholding from the ancient church. Its very singularity is instructive. The theological materials for abolition - creation, divine ownership, human freedom - were present, but most Christians did not assemble them into a general social demand. Moral insight is not produced by doctrine alone. It requires attention, conflict, communities willing to act, and often the testimony of those who bear the institution's violence.

Later abolitionists sometimes searched the early church for a pure antislavery inheritance. They found examples of manumission, spiritual equality, and ransom, but not a continuous abolitionist movement. The honest legacy is more complex: early Christianity weakened some ideological foundations of slavery by universalizing moral worth, while churches normalized slavery for centuries. Gregory's question survived like a buried charge. Much later, abolitionists would detonate it.

Gregory of Nyssa

c. 335-c. 395

BISHOP AND THEOLOGIAN

CENTRAL IDEA

Because every person bears God's image and belongs to God, buying a human being is an absurd claim to own what cannot be priced.

KEY WRITINGS / ACTIONS *Homilies on Ecclesiastes, especially Homily 4*

Chapter notes and source trail

1. Jennifer A. Glancy, *Slavery in Early Christianity*; Chris L. de Wet, *Preaching Bondage: John Chrysostom and the Discourse of Slavery in Early Christianity* (University of California Press, 2015).
2. Augustine, *City of God*, 19.15; see also David Brion Davis, *The Problem of Slavery in Western Culture*.
3. Gregory of Nyssa, Homily 4 on Ecclesiastes, in Stuart George Hall and Rachel Moriarty, trans., *Gregory of Nyssa: Homilies on Ecclesiastes* (de Gruyter, 1993).
4. David Bentley Hart, 'The Whole Humanity: Gregory of Nyssa's Critique of Slavery,' and Ilaria L. E. Ramelli, discussions of Gregory's antislavery argument; Cambridge scholarship identifies the sermon as exceptional in antiquity.
5. For caution against triumphalist accounts, see Jennifer Glancy and the Cambridge histories of slavery and Christianity.

CHAPTER 3

Medieval Christianity

FIFTH TO FIFTEENTH CENTURIES | Manumission, bondage, and the moral boundaries of Christendom

As Rome's western empire fragmented, slavery changed rather than simply disappeared. Captivity, household slavery, agricultural bondage, and serfdom overlapped. Christian teaching softened some edges and hardened others.

Medieval Europe contained many forms of unfreedom. Some people were chattel slaves; many more were serfs bound to land, lord, dues, and inherited obligations. War and raiding supplied captives. Mediterranean markets trafficked Slavs, Greeks, Muslims, Africans, and Christians. The boundaries were often religious as well as political: rulers and merchants found it easier to enslave outsiders, heretics, prisoners, or people beyond the imagined community of Christendom.¹

Churches encouraged manumission as a meritorious act. Wills freed enslaved people for the donor's soul; monasteries ransomed captives; canon law objected to certain sales and protected some marriages. Baptism established spiritual equality, and the Christian calendar sometimes became an occasion for release. At the same time, bishops, monasteries, and religious institutions held dependent laborers and enslaved people. Ecclesiastical property could reproduce the same coercive relations that sermons urged masters to humanize.²

Natural equality, legal inequality

Scholastic theologians inherited Aristotle's language of natural slavery but usually modified it. Thomas Aquinas affirmed that no human being was by nature ordered to another in the deepest sense of creation; dominion over persons arose through human law and the consequences of sin. That distinction preserved a doctrine of natural equality while allowing civil slavery to remain. The pattern would recur for centuries: Christianity could proclaim equal souls and unequal bodies, universal redemption and inherited subordination.³

This tension mattered because later abolitionists drew on the universal side of the tradition. If domination belonged to fallen convention rather than creation, it could be judged. If human law contradicted natural law and charity, it lacked moral authority. Yet medieval Christianity rarely took the next step toward universal abolition. It produced restraints, routes to freedom, and critiques of unjust

enslavement. It did not produce a sustained institution-wide demand that every master release every slave.

The frontier problem

The moral circle contracted at frontiers. Crusade, reconquest, and conflict with Muslim polities created categories of licit captivity. Christian Europeans could condemn the enslavement of fellow Christians while participating in the enslavement of Muslims, pagans, and people labeled enemies. This selective ethic prepared a fatal logic for the age of exploration: equal dignity might be acknowledged in principle, while conquest and religious difference supplied exceptions large enough to build an empire.

The medieval story therefore resists the claim that Christianity steadily eliminated slavery. In some regions, chattel slavery declined and serfdom became more common; in others, slave markets flourished. Economic change, state formation, warfare, demography, and geography mattered alongside religion. Christianity shaped whom people felt obligated to protect. It also shaped whom they allowed themselves not to see.

Chapter notes and source trail

1. Alice Rio, *Slavery After Rome, 500-1100* (Oxford University Press, 2017); Hannah Barker, *That Most Precious Merchandise: The Mediterranean Trade in Black Sea Slaves, 1260-1500* (University of Pennsylvania Press, 2019).
2. David Brion Davis, *The Problem of Slavery in Western Culture*; institutional manumission and captive redemption varied greatly by region.
3. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, I, q. 96, a. 4 and II-II discussions of justice and dominion; see Jean Allain, *The Legal Understanding of Slavery* (Oxford University Press, 2012).
4. For distinctions between slavery and serfdom, see Robert Bartlett, *The Making of Europe* (Princeton University Press, 1993), and Alice Rio.
5. The chapter uses 'medieval Christianity' as a broad category and does not imply a uniform legal or ecclesial system.

CHAPTER 4

Conquest, Empire, and the Atlantic Slave System

FIFTEENTH TO SEVENTEENTH CENTURIES | Papal prohibitions, papal permissions, prophetic protest, and the making of racial bondage

In the Atlantic world, Christianity arrived on both sides of the chain: as a warrant carried by conquerors and as a judgment spoken against them.

Canary Islands: an early warning

In 1435 Pope Eugene IV issued *Sicut Dudum* after Christians enslaved baptized inhabitants of the Canary Islands. The bull ordered captives restored to liberty under threat of excommunication. It was a real defense of particular people and an important precedent. It was not a universal abolition of slavery. The document's protective force was tied to Christian status and a contested mission field, illustrating the era's persistent distinction between unjust enslavement and slavery as such.¹

Permission and empire

Within two decades, other papal documents helped Portugal frame expansion as holy war and evangelization. *Dum Diversas* (1452) and *Romanus Pontifex* (1455) granted the Portuguese crown authority over lands and enemies described as Saracens and pagans, including language permitting perpetual servitude. These bulls did not invent African slavery, but they gave Christian-legal sanction to conquest at the moment Portuguese trading networks were becoming Atlantic systems. In later centuries, colonizers would treat religious authorization as property title.²

The contradiction was not accidental. European Christians condemned some enslavements while authorizing others, depending on baptism, sovereignty, war, and imperial interest. The same church could defend Canary Islanders and legitimate campaigns elsewhere. Christianity's universal claims were filtered through political categories: believer and infidel, civilized and barbarous, subject and enemy. Those categories were gradually racialized until African ancestry itself became a presumptive mark of enslavability.

Montesinos and the shock of recognition

On the fourth Sunday of Advent in 1511, Dominican friar Antonio de Montesinos preached before Spanish colonists on Hispaniola. Speaking for his community, he demanded to know by what right the colonists held Indigenous people in cruel servitude. His questions broke through legal euphemism: 'Are these not men? Have they not rational souls?' The sermon did not immediately end colonial exploitation, but it created a Christian vocabulary of accusation. Confession and communion, Montesinos implied, could not be separated from the bodies worked to death outside the church.³

“Are these not men? Have they not rational souls?”

- Antonio de Montesinos, Advent sermon on Hispaniola (1511)

Las Casas: conversion, failure, repentance

Bartolome de las Casas, once a participant in the encomienda system, underwent a long conversion into its most famous Christian critic. He argued that Indigenous peoples possessed reason, legitimate societies, property, and the right to receive the gospel without violence. His Short Account of the Destruction of the Indies exposed conquest as a catastrophe of greed and cruelty. Yet Las Casas's history carries its own wound: early in his reform efforts he endorsed importing Africans as an alternative labor force. He later regretted this and condemned African enslavement, but the episode shows how moral concern can remain trapped inside the search for a substitute victim.⁴

Sublimis Deus - and limits of enforcement

In 1537 Pope Paul III's Sublimis Deus declared that Indigenous peoples and others encountered by Christians were rational beings capable of faith and were 'by no means to be deprived of their liberty.' The declaration undercut theories that conquest erased humanity. Enforcement was weak, colonial interests resisted, and legal loopholes survived. Still, the document became part of a Catholic antislavery archive later invoked against enslavement.⁵

A Black Catholic abolitionist before abolitionism

In the late seventeenth century, Lourenco da Silva Mendonca, a man of African royal ancestry connected to Angola and Brazil, carried a case to Rome against the Atlantic slave trade and the treatment of Africans and New Christians. Working through Black confraternities and transatlantic Catholic networks, he denounced the 'tyrannical sale of human beings.' His petition is crucial because it overturns the

picture of antislavery conscience flowing only from European benevolence. Black Catholics used the church's universal claims to prosecute Christendom before its own courts.⁶

Lourenco da Silva Mendonca

fl. 1670s-1680s

BLACK CATHOLIC
PETITIONER AND
DIPLOMAT

CENTRAL IDEA

Christian law and sacramental brotherhood made the enslavement and sale of Africans a scandal that Rome was obligated to judge.

KEY WRITINGS / ACTIONS *Petition to the Vatican's Congregation of the Holy Office; organizing through Black confraternities*

By 1700, the moral ingredients of abolition were visible: human equality, freedom as a natural condition, critique of violent conversion, eyewitness testimony, Black petitioning, and ecclesiastical condemnation. Yet Atlantic slavery expanded. Sugar, shipping, credit, war, and state power proved stronger than scattered protest. The next breakthrough would come when dissenters turned isolated conscience into a disciplined movement.

Chapter notes and source trail

1. Eugene IV, *Sicut Dudum* (1435). The bull ordered restoration of Canary Islanders who had been enslaved; its scope was specific rather than a universal abolition decree.
2. Nicholas V, *Dum Diversas* (1452) and *Romanus Pontifex* (1455). The Vatican's 2023 Joint Statement on the 'Doctrine of Discovery' acknowledges that such bulls were manipulated for political purposes and did not adequately reflect the equal dignity and rights of Indigenous peoples.
3. Library of Congress, 'The Laws of Burgos: 500 Years of Human Rights,' discussion of Antonio de Montesinos's 1511 sermon.
4. Bartolome de las Casas, *A Short Account of the Destruction of the Indies* (1552); Ohio State Origins, 'Bartolome de las Casas and 500 Years of Racial Injustice,' on his later regret concerning African slavery.
5. Paul III, *Sublimis Deus* (1537); Vatican 2023 Joint Statement reproduces the key liberty language.
6. Jose Lingna Nafafe, *Lourenco da Silva Mendonca and the Black Atlantic Abolitionist Movement in the Seventeenth Century* (Cambridge University Press, 2022).

CHAPTER 5

The Quaker Breakthrough

1688 TO THE 1770S | From private unease to corporate discipline

The decisive Quaker innovation was not the discovery that slavery could be cruel. It was the slow creation of a community willing to discipline its own members for participating in it.

Germantown, 1688

Four German-speaking Friends near Philadelphia drafted a short protest against slavery in 1688. They applied the Golden Rule across race and geography: Christians should do to others what they would want done to themselves. They also understood reputation. How could Friends condemn persecution in Europe while buying people in Pennsylvania? The meeting did not adopt the protest as policy; it was passed upward and effectively shelved. Yet its logic was clear: slavery violated neighbor-love and discredited Christian witness.¹

Early Quaker antislavery was uneven. George Fox urged humane treatment and religious instruction and later pressed for eventual freedom, but Quakers in the Caribbean and North America owned enslaved people. Wealth from Atlantic commerce touched Quaker families and meetings. The movement's power came not from original innocence but from a process of internal argument in which dissenters forced a religious society to make its discipline match its testimony.

Benjamin Lay: holy disruption

Benjamin Lay, a physically disabled, uncompromising Friend, treated slaveholding as a 'notorious sin.' He staged dramatic protests, refused goods connected to slave labor, and publicly confronted respected Quaker owners. To polite meetings he seemed theatrical and disorderly. That was the point. Lay understood that an institution protected by manners required moral interruption. He made complicity visible in rooms designed to keep it abstract.²

Anthony Benezet: evidence and education

Anthony Benezet joined evangelical compassion to patient documentation. He corresponded across the Atlantic, collected accounts of African societies and the slave trade, taught Black children, and wrote pamphlets that influenced British abolitionists. Benezet rejected the fiction that Africans were naturally fitted for

bondage. Ignorance and degradation were results of oppression, not evidence of inferiority. His method - testimony, statistics, correspondence, popular print - became the movement's research infrastructure.³

John Woolman: the inward light becomes social judgment

John Woolman traveled among Friends, speaking gently but persistently against slaveholding. His Journal reveals a conscience trained to notice how ordinary comfort rested on distant suffering. Woolman refused to write bills of sale, challenged luxurious consumption, paid enslaved people directly when hosted by owners, and connected slavery with war, wealth, and the human desire to dominate. He made abolition a practice of daily integrity, not merely an opinion.⁴

“May we look upon our treasures, and try whether the seeds of war have nourishment in them.”

- John Woolman, *A Plea for the Poor* (published 1793)

By the 1750s and 1760s, Quaker meetings in Pennsylvania, New Jersey, and elsewhere tightened discipline against importing, buying, and eventually owning enslaved people. The process was slow, contested, and incomplete, but it marked a structural advance. A church body began to say that participation in slavery was incompatible with membership. This created trained organizers, transatlantic correspondence, petitioning habits, and a moral vocabulary later carried into national campaigns.

The limits of Quaker emancipation

Even principled manumission could leave freed people landless and vulnerable. Some Quakers favored gradual rather than immediate emancipation. Racial prejudice survived antislavery conviction. Black activists therefore pressed beyond the conscience of white reformers toward citizenship, education, economic justice, and institutional independence. Nevertheless, the Quaker achievement was decisive: it transformed scattered witness into a reproducible movement culture.

**Anthony
Benezet**

1713-1784

TEACHER, PAMPHLETEER,
NETWORK BUILDER

CENTRAL IDEA

Racial hierarchy was manufactured by violence and denied by the Golden Rule; accurate knowledge of Africa could destroy excuses for enslavement.

KEY WRITINGS / ACTIONS *A Short Account of That Part of Africa Inhabited by the Negroes* (1762); *Some Historical Account of Guinea* (1771)

Chapter notes and source trail

1. Germantown Friends' Protest Against Slavery (1688), Library of Congress facsimile and transcription.
2. Marcus Rediker, *The Fearless Benjamin Lay: The Quaker Dwarf Who Became the First Revolutionary Abolitionist* (Beacon Press, 2017); Library of Congress abolition exhibit.
3. Anthony Benezet, *Some Historical Account of Guinea* (1771); Library of Congress, 'The African-American Mosaic: Abolition.'
4. John Woolman, *The Journal of John Woolman and A Plea for the Poor*, Project Gutenberg editions.
5. Jean R. Soderlund, *Quakers and Slavery: A Divided Spirit* (Princeton University Press, 1985).

CHAPTER 6

Evangelical Conscience and the British Campaign

1770S TO 1807 | Testimony, revival, political organization, and the destruction of the slave trade

The British abolition campaign joined Quaker organization, evangelical conversion, Black testimony, popular mobilization, and parliamentary strategy. Its heroes mattered, but the movement was far larger than its famous parliamentarian.

Wesley and Methodist antislavery

John Wesley's *Thoughts upon Slavery* (1774), drawing heavily on Benezet, attacked the trade's violence and the claim that custom could create a right to own persons. Wesley's language was theological and natural-rights based: every human creature received liberty from God. Early Methodists carried antislavery rules into the United States, though enforcement weakened as the church expanded in slaveholding regions. Revival could awaken conscience; it could also be domesticated by institutional ambition.¹

Equiano: witness becomes argument

Olaudah Equiano's *Interesting Narrative* (1789) brought readers through capture, the Atlantic crossing, enslavement, seafaring, conversion, self-purchase, and abolitionist activism. Equiano wrote as an African, a Briton, a sailor, and a Christian. He exposed the contradiction between the gospel Europeans preached and the commerce they practiced. His cry, 'O, ye nominal Christians!' made hypocrisy a form of evidence. Conversion did not reconcile him to bondage; it furnished language with which to indict it.²

"O, ye nominal Christians! Might not an African ask you, learned you this from your God?"

- Olaudah Equiano, *The Interesting Narrative* (1789)

Equiano was part of a wider Black abolitionist public. Ottobah Cugoano demanded immediate emancipation and rejected the idea that Africans owed obedience to kidnappers. The Sons of Africa organized, petitioned, published, and

advised white allies. Their presence mattered because British abolition was not a charitable conversation about absent victims. Black writers entered the room as political thinkers.

Clarkson's road

Thomas Clarkson turned research into organizing. He traveled thousands of miles, interviewed sailors, collected shackles and trade goods, gathered medical testimony, and built local committees. The famous diagram of the slave ship *Brookes* converted cargo mathematics into a visual horror: human beings packed into measured spaces. Abolitionists pioneered consumer boycotts of slave-grown sugar, petitions bearing hundreds of thousands of names, public lectures, print networks, and the strategic use of material evidence.³

Wilberforce and the parliamentary struggle

William Wilberforce, transformed by evangelical faith, became the campaign's parliamentary voice. His conversion persuaded him that public office was a vocation, not a retreat from holiness. Working with the Clapham circle and allies such as Hannah More, James Stephen, Granville Sharp, and Henry Thornton, he repeatedly introduced abolition measures. In his 1789 speech, after laying out evidence of kidnapping, mortality, and abuse, he told Parliament that 'we can no longer plead ignorance.'⁴

The campaign suffered defeats. War with revolutionary France made reformers vulnerable to charges of radicalism. West Indian interests defended property, empire, and shipping. Some supporters favored gradual measures that left people suffering for years. Meanwhile, the Haitian Revolution terrified slave societies and proved enslaved people were historical actors, not passive recipients of humanitarian rescue. British abolition emerged from this conflict between moral agitation, geopolitical change, rebellion, and state interest.

1807: a victory, not an ending

Parliament abolished the British slave trade in 1807. The law ended legal British participation in transporting newly enslaved Africans, but it did not free people already enslaved in British colonies. Nor did it end illegal trafficking. Abolitionists had won a national moral commitment that the trade was criminal; they had not yet destroyed plantation slavery. The movement now faced a harder question: could an empire that condemned kidnapping continue to protect ownership?

Olaudah Equiano

c. 1745-1797

**AUTHOR, SAILOR,
ABOLITIONIST**

CENTRAL IDEA

Christian conversion and African testimony exposed European slave trading as a betrayal of the religion used to justify empire.

KEY WRITINGS / ACTIONS *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano (1789); petitions and organizing with the Sons of Africa*

Chapter notes and source trail

1. John Wesley, *Thoughts upon Slavery* (1774), Project Gutenberg; Wesley's final 1791 letter encouraged Wilberforce not to be 'weary of well-doing.'
2. Olaudah Equiano, *The Interesting Narrative* (1789), Project Gutenberg and Library of Congress editions; Vincent Carretta, *Equiano, the African* (University of Georgia Press, 2005).
3. Thomas Clarkson, *The History of the Rise, Progress, and Accomplishment of the Abolition of the African Slave-Trade* (1808); J. R. Oldfield, *Popular Politics and British Anti-Slavery* (Manchester University Press, 1995).
4. UK Parliament, William Wilberforce's 1789 abolition speech and biographical materials.
5. Christopher Leslie Brown, *Moral Capital: Foundations of British Abolitionism* (University of North Carolina Press, 2006); Seymour Drescher, *Capitalism and Antislavery* (Oxford University Press, 1987).
6. Slave Trade Act 1807, 47 Geo. III Sess. 1 c. 36.

CHAPTER 7

The Caribbean Crucible

1791 TO 1838 | Rebellion, mission, testimony, and emancipation

British emancipation was debated in London, but its urgency was made in Caribbean fields, chapels, prisons, and rebellions.

Haiti and the fear of Black freedom

The Haitian Revolution began in 1791 in Saint-Domingue, the wealthiest slave colony in the Atlantic world, and culminated in independence in 1804. Enslaved rebels drew on African religious traditions, Catholic symbols, revolutionary rights language, military experience, and the immediate knowledge that freedom would not be given voluntarily. European abolitionists were divided: some celebrated the destruction of slavery; others recoiled from violence or feared Black sovereignty. Haiti permanently altered the possible. A slave society had been overthrown by the enslaved.¹

Christianity in the Caribbean was itself divided. Planters often resisted missionary teaching because literacy, marriage, spiritual equality, and independent assembly could weaken control. Missionaries sometimes preached obedience and accepted colonial hierarchy. Yet chapels created networks through which enslaved people exchanged news, elected leaders, interpreted scripture, and imagined collective action. The Bible's Exodus did not remain safely metaphorical when read by people in bondage.

Mary Prince: the authority of suffering

The History of Mary Prince (1831), the first published account of an enslaved Black woman from the British Caribbean, carried the violence of Bermudian and Antiguan slavery into British homes. Prince described labor, beating, family separation, sexual vulnerability, and her struggle for freedom. Her Christian language challenged readers to recognize that respectable colonial households were built upon terror. Proslavery critics attacked her credibility, revealing how much the slave system depended on preventing the enslaved from narrating themselves.²

Sam Sharpe and the Baptist War

Samuel Sharpe, an enslaved Baptist deacon in Jamaica, helped organize a general strike at Christmas 1831. Participants intended to withhold labor until they

received wages and freedom. When confrontation escalated, the uprising spread across the island. Colonial forces crushed it with severe violence, executing Sharpe and many others and destroying Baptist chapels. The rebellion demonstrated both the organizing capacity of enslaved Christians and the depth of planter resistance.³

“I would rather die upon yonder gallows than live in slavery.”

- Words traditionally attributed to Samuel Sharpe before his execution, 1832

Sharpe's remembered declaration expresses the moral reversal at abolitionism's heart. Colonial law called the rebel criminal and the master owner. Christian abolitionism increasingly called the system criminal and resistance intelligible. British missionaries' reports of repression, combined with the revolt itself, accelerated public pressure. Enslaved action and metropolitan campaigning were not rival explanations for emancipation; they were interacting forces.

1833 and the scandal of compensation

The Slavery Abolition Act of 1833 provided for emancipation across most of the British Empire, but it compensated slaveholders rather than the enslaved. The state treated owners' loss of property as payable while treating generations of stolen labor as beyond calculation. Formerly enslaved people were forced into an 'apprenticeship' system that preserved planter control and coercion. Protest by apprentices, missionaries, and abolitionists helped end apprenticeship in 1838.⁴

Emancipation celebrations often used biblical imagery: Jubilee, Exodus, dawn, and resurrection. Yet freedom came without land redistribution or reparations. Plantation economies sought new dependent labor, and racial hierarchy endured. The Christian campaign had helped destroy legal ownership, but abolition in law proved narrower than liberation in life.

Samuel Sharpe

c. 1801-1832

ENSLAVED BAPTIST
DEACON AND ORGANIZER

CENTRAL IDEA

Faith made freedom a present claim, not merely a heavenly promise; disciplined collective refusal could expose the illegitimacy of mastery.

KEY WRITINGS / ACTIONS *Organization of the 1831 Christmas strike and Baptist War in Jamaica*

Chapter notes and source trail

1. Laurent Dubois, *Avengers of the New World: The Story of the Haitian Revolution* (Harvard University Press, 2004); the revolution's religious world combined African and Christian elements.
2. Mary Prince, *The History of Mary Prince, a West Indian Slave* (1831); Moira Ferguson, ed., revised critical editions.

3. UK National Archives, material on Samuel Sharpe and the 1831-32 Jamaican rebellion; Gelien Matthews, *Caribbean Slave Revolts and the British Abolitionist Movement* (Louisiana State University Press, 2006).
4. Slavery Abolition Act 1833; apprenticeship ended in 1838 after sustained protest.
5. Catherine Hall, *Civilising Subjects: Metropole and Colony in the English Imagination, 1830-1867* (University of Chicago Press, 2002).

CHAPTER 8

Black Churches and a Prophetic Abolitionism

1770S TO 1840S | Institution building, self-emancipation, and the theology of a people

Black Christianity did more than add eloquent witnesses to abolition. It created institutions in which people denied public authority could preach, govern, educate, publish, shelter, mourn, and organize.

Petition and exodus

In 1777, Prince Hall and other Black petitioners in Massachusetts appealed for freedom by invoking natural rights and the 'mild religion of Jesus.' Their petition joined revolutionary language to Christian judgment. White patriots who resisted political slavery while holding people in bondage had made their own hypocrisy visible. Black petitioners repeatedly used that contradiction: if liberty was a gift of God and a right of humanity, it could not stop at color.¹

Allen, Jones, and the walkout

In Philadelphia, Black Methodists Richard Allen and Absalom Jones helped build St. George's Methodist Church through their labor and fundraising. As the Black congregation grew, white leaders imposed segregation. During worship, officials attempted to remove Jones while he prayed in a newly restricted area. Black members walked out. From that humiliation came the Free African Society, African Episcopal Church of St. Thomas, and Bethel African Methodist Episcopal Church. Independence was not sectarian vanity; it was protection against a church that preached spiritual equality while enforcing racial subordination.²

Richard Allen's leadership joined evangelical discipline, economic self-help, mutual aid, education, and abolition. The African Methodist Episcopal Church, formally organized in 1816, created a national institution governed by Black Christians. Pulpits became schools of political thought. Churches hosted antislavery meetings, aided fugitives, raised funds, published newspapers, and trained leaders. They also gave Black communities authority over their own sacred story.

David Walker: an appeal that sounded like judgment

David Walker's *Appeal to the Coloured Citizens of the World* (1829) was militant, biblical, and international. Walker denounced colonization, white Christian hypocrisy, and the demand that oppressed people wait patiently for justice. He rejected racial inferiority and reminded Black readers of ancient civilizations and divine judgment. His punctuation itself seemed to shout from the page: 'Are we MEN!!' Southern authorities treated the pamphlet as dangerous, passing laws against Black literacy and circulation.³

"Are we MEN!! - I ask you, O my brethren!"

- David Walker, *Appeal to the Coloured Citizens of the World* (1829)

Maria Stewart and the authority of Black women

Maria W. Stewart, influenced by Walker and published by William Lloyd Garrison, became one of the first American women to address mixed public audiences on politics. She fused biblical exhortation, Black nationalism, education, and women's moral agency. Stewart rebuked white oppression and challenged Black men to cultivate courage and intellectual ambition. Her public speech violated both racial hierarchy and the gendered expectation that a woman remain silent.⁴

Garnet, Delany, and the debate over resistance

Henry Highland Garnet's 1843 'Address to the Slaves of the United States' urged enslaved people to resist, declaring that submission could not be a Christian duty when masters violated every human bond. The National Negro Convention declined to adopt the address, reflecting strategic disagreement among Black abolitionists. Some emphasized moral suasion, some political action, some migration, some armed resistance, and many moved among these positions. Their disagreements were not signs of weakness. They were arguments about how a people under violence could act responsibly without accepting passivity.⁵

Black churches also complicated white abolitionism. They criticized paternalism, segregated meetings, colonization schemes, and a definition of freedom that ended with legal release. Their abolitionism demanded citizenship, schools, land, family security, voting rights, and protection from racial terror. Emancipation without equality was an unfinished exodus.

Richard Allen

1760-1831

**MINISTER, BISHOP,
INSTITUTION BUILDER****CENTRAL IDEA**

A church that denied Black Christians dignity in worship could not be the sole guardian of their freedom; independent institutions were a form of emancipation.

KEY WRITINGS / ACTIONS *Founder of Mother Bethel AME; first bishop of the African Methodist Episcopal Church; autobiographical and antislavery writings*

Chapter notes and source trail

1. Library of Congress, 'African American Odyssey' and abolition exhibits on the 1777 Prince Hall petition and early Black petitions.
2. Richard S. Newman, *Freedom's Prophet: Bishop Richard Allen, the AME Church, and the Black Founding Fathers* (New York University Press, 2008); Library of Congress biography of Richard Allen.
3. David Walker, *Appeal to the Coloured Citizens of the World* (1829), Project Gutenberg and Library of Congress editions.
4. Maria W. Stewart, *Productions of Mrs. Maria W. Stewart* (1835); Library of Congress Civil Rights Act exhibit biography.
5. Henry Highland Garnet, 'An Address to the Slaves of the United States of America' (1843); see also Manisha Sinha, *The Slave's Cause*.
6. Albert J. Raboteau, *Slave Religion: The 'Invisible Institution' in the Antebellum South* (Oxford University Press, 1978; rev. ed. 2004).

CHAPTER 9

The Battle for the Bible in the United States

1830S TO 1860 | Immediate abolition, proslavery theology, and churches torn apart

By the 1830s, slavery was not merely an issue before American churches. It was an institution inside them: in pews, pulpits, mission boards, seminaries, donations, and denominational budgets.

Garrison and the demand for immediacy

William Lloyd Garrison launched *The Liberator* in 1831 with a promise that moral urgency would no longer be softened into gradualism: 'I will not retreat a single inch - and I will be heard.' Garrison treated slavery as a present sin requiring immediate repentance, not a regrettable inheritance to be phased out at the owner's convenience. His perfectionist Christianity made compromise dangerous; his rejection of colonization insisted that Black Americans belonged in the nation they had built.¹

Garrison's movement used moral suasion: expose sin, awaken conscience, demand withdrawal from complicity. It built antislavery societies, lecture circuits, fairs, newspapers, and petition campaigns. Yet Garrison's denunciation of churches and the Constitution alienated political abolitionists. Frederick Douglass eventually rejected Garrison's reading of the Constitution as irredeemably proslavery, arguing that it could be interpreted as a freedom document. Abolitionism was a coalition and an argument.

The Bible Against Slavery

Theodore Dwight Weld's *The Bible Against Slavery* (1837) attacked the claim that biblical servitude justified American chattel slavery. Weld distinguished Hebrew debt service from hereditary racial property, emphasized the law against man-stealing, and read the Golden Rule as incompatible with ownership. Angelina and Sarah Grimke, raised in a South Carolina slaveholding family, added eyewitness authority. Angelina's *Appeal to the Christian Women of the South* urged women to read, pray, speak, petition, and act even without the vote.²

The proslavery counteroffensive

Southern clergy did not merely apologize for slavery; many developed a confident theology of it. Thornton Stringfellow assembled biblical examples to argue that slaveholding was sanctioned by scripture. James Henley Thornwell treated social hierarchy as part of providential order and warned that abolition threatened civilization. Benjamin Morgan Palmer called slavery a 'divine trust' in his 1860 Thanksgiving sermon. Robert Lewis Dabney later defended Virginia and slavery through biblical, racial, and constitutional argument.³

Proslavery theology gained strength from a literal question: where did scripture explicitly condemn the relation of master and slave? It accused abolitionists of replacing revelation with modern sentiment. Abolitionists replied that slaveholders had replaced the Bible's moral center with its ancient social surface. The conflict revealed a weakness in proof-text ethics. A method that treated every regulated practice as permanently legitimate could baptize almost any inherited power.

"The slave auctioneer's bell and the church-going bell chime in with each other."

- Frederick Douglass, *What to the Slave Is the Fourth of July?* (1852)

Denominations fracture

Church structures cracked under the pressure. American Methodism had inherited an antislavery rule, but expansion in the South produced accommodation. In 1844, conflict over Bishop James O. Andrew's connection to slaveholding helped divide the Methodist Episcopal Church into northern and southern bodies. Baptists separated in 1845 amid controversy over whether slaveholders could be appointed as missionaries, leading to the formation of the Southern Baptist Convention. Presbyterians experienced repeated sectional divisions sharpened by slavery and war.⁴

These splits were moral events, not only administrative ones. Denominations often chose organizational peace until peace was impossible, then created separate institutions rather than establish a common antislavery discipline. The result was a religious map that mirrored the political map of secession. Churches had helped form sectional identities strong enough to survive appeals to Christian unity.

Douglass's distinction

Frederick Douglass refused to let slaveholding Christians define Christianity. In the appendix to his *Narrative*, he distinguished 'the Christianity of Christ' from the

corrupt Christianity of the land. This was both theological rescue and indictment. Douglass could quote prophets, expose pious cruelty, preach in Black churches, and still condemn the religious forms that blessed the whip. His distinction allowed abolitionists to oppose Christian power in the name of Christian truth.⁵

Frederick Douglass

c. 1818-1895

FORMERLY ENSLAVED
AUTHOR, ORATOR,
EDITOR, REFORMER

CENTRAL IDEA

Authentic Christianity is measured by solidarity with the oppressed; a church allied with slavery becomes evidence against itself.

KEY WRITINGS / ACTIONS *Narrative (1845); The North Star; What to the Slave Is the Fourth of July? (1852); speeches on church complicity and constitutional antislavery*

Chapter notes and source trail

1. William Lloyd Garrison, *The Liberator*, first editorial, January 1, 1831; *No Compromise with Slavery* (1854), Project Gutenberg.
2. Theodore Dwight Weld, *The Bible Against Slavery* (1837), Library of Congress; Angelina Grimke, *Appeal to the Christian Women of the South* (1836), Project Gutenberg / Library of Congress.
3. Thornton Stringfellow, *Scriptural and Statistical Views in Favor of Slavery* (1856), Documenting the American South; James Henley Thornwell, Benjamin Morgan Palmer, and Robert Lewis Dabney primary texts.
4. United Methodist Church historical materials on slavery and the 1844 split; Southern Baptist Convention, 1995 Resolution on Racial Reconciliation, acknowledging its history and apology for condoning and perpetuating racism and the legacy of slavery.
5. Frederick Douglass, *Narrative* (1845), Appendix; *What to the Slave Is the Fourth of July?* (1852).
6. Mark A. Noll, *The Civil War as a Theological Crisis*; John Patrick Daly, *When Slavery Was Called Freedom: Evangelicalism, Proslavery, and the Causes of the Civil War* (University Press of Kentucky, 2002).

CHAPTER 10

Women, Print, and the Enlargement of Moral Agency

1830S TO 1850S | How abolition transformed who could speak in public

Abolition asked women to petition, raise funds, circulate books, host fugitives, and testify. Then it discovered that people trusted with moral labor would also claim moral authority.

The Grimke sisters

Sarah and Angelina Grimke carried the intimate knowledge of a slaveholding household into northern abolition. Angelina's Appeal addressed southern Christian women not as powerless ornaments but as readers of scripture and makers of moral culture. She asked them to examine the system, teach enslaved people, petition lawmakers and churches, and accept the consequences of obedience to conscience. When the sisters lectured to mixed audiences, ministers condemned not only their antislavery message but their violation of female silence.¹

Sarah's Letters on the Equality of the Sexes argued that the same interpretive habits used to justify slavery were used to subordinate women: selective texts, inherited custom, and claims that hierarchy reflected nature. Abolition became a school of feminist analysis. The movement forced reformers to ask whether universal moral equality could be defended in one relation and denied in another.

Antislavery fairs and the economy of persuasion

Women organized antislavery fairs, sold handmade goods, published gift books, managed correspondence, and sustained societies. These activities are sometimes described as auxiliary work because they were coded as domestic. In fact, they financed newspapers and lecturers, created consumer networks, and turned household purchasing into politics. The sugar boycott made the breakfast table a site of imperial accountability. A spoonful of sugar could carry the labor of a plantation into a British or American home.²

Harriet Beecher Stowe and moral imagination

Uncle Tom's Cabin (1852) became one of the century's most influential antislavery books. Stowe used domestic fiction, evangelical sentiment, family

separation, deathbed piety, and direct address to make readers feel the incompatibility of slave law and Christian love. The novel's stereotypes and paternalism have rightly drawn criticism, especially its later transformation into racist stage caricature. Yet its original political force lay in making complicity emotional and immediate for a mass readership.³

Stowe followed the novel with *A Key to Uncle Tom's Cabin*, presenting documents, laws, advertisements, and testimonies to answer critics who called the story exaggerated. This union of narrative and archive was characteristic of abolitionism. Feeling alone could be dismissed as sentiment; evidence alone could be ignored. Together they made a moral world.

Sojourner Truth and the problem of the record

Sojourner Truth, born enslaved as Isabella Baumfree, became an itinerant preacher and reformer. She spoke through biblical stories, personal experience, humor, and physical presence. Her famous 1851 Akron speech survives in different versions. The widely repeated phrase 'Ain't I a Woman?' appears in Frances Dana Gage's 1863 reconstruction, not in Marius Robinson's closer 1851 report. The discrepancy matters: later editors gave Truth a stereotyped southern dialect she did not speak. Historical respect requires listening to her without remaking her voice for dramatic effect.⁴

Truth linked abolition, women's rights, labor, and divine calling. Her authority did not depend on formal education. It came from survival, scriptural fluency, public courage, and the ability to expose contradictions in the language of weakness. White society used womanhood to claim women needed protection while denying Black women both protection and recognition. Truth's presence broke that logic open.

"I have as much muscle as any man, and can do as much work as any man."

- Sojourner Truth, reported by Marius Robinson after the Akron convention (1851)

Angelina Grimke

1805-1879

ABOLITIONIST WRITER
AND LECTURER

CENTRAL IDEA

Christian women were morally responsible to resist slavery even when law and custom denied them formal political power.

KEY WRITINGS / ACTIONS *Appeal to the Christian Women of the South* (1836); public lectures; antislavery and women's-rights writings

Chapter notes and source trail

1. Angelina Grimke, *Appeal to the Christian Women of the South* (1836); Sarah Grimke, *Letters on the Equality of the Sexes and the Condition of Woman* (1837-38).
2. Julie Roy Jeffrey, *The Great Silent Army of Abolitionism: Ordinary Women in the Antislavery Movement* (University of North Carolina Press, 1998).
3. Harriet Beecher Stowe, *Uncle Tom's Cabin* (1852) and *A Key to Uncle Tom's Cabin* (1853); David S. Reynolds, *Mightier than the Sword* (W. W. Norton, 2011).
4. National Park Service, *Sojourner Truth and the textual history of the Akron speech*; Marius Robinson's 1851 report and Frances Dana Gage's 1863 version should not be conflated.
5. Margaret Washington, *Sojourner Truth's America* (University of Illinois Press, 2009).

CHAPTER 11

Resistance, the Underground Railroad, and Holy Disobedience

1793 TO 1860 | When obedience to God meant breaking the law

Fugitive slave laws forced a question that sermons could postpone: when the state commands the return of a human being to bondage, what does Christian obedience require?

A network, not a railroad

The Underground Railroad was a shifting network of fugitives, free Black communities, sailors, laborers, farmers, ministers, vigilance committees, and safe houses. Its central actors were the people who escaped. Assistance could include directions, food, forged papers, transport, legal defense, armed protection, or fundraising. Black churches in northern cities were especially important because they combined trust, local knowledge, and institutional space.¹

The Fugitive Slave Act of 1850 nationalized complicity. Federal law denied alleged fugitives ordinary legal protections and punished assistance. Northern citizens could no longer imagine slavery as a distant southern institution. To obey the law might mean helping kidnap a neighbor. Resistance drew on the apostles' declaration, 'We ought to obey God rather than men,' and on a natural-law tradition that unjust commands lacked moral authority.

Harriet Tubman: faith under pressure

Harriet Tubman escaped from Maryland in 1849 and repeatedly returned to guide family members and others toward freedom. Her faith was intensely personal, shaped by biblical language, visions, prayer, spirituals, and African American religious culture. She believed divine guidance operated through practical intelligence: careful timing, knowledge of terrain, trusted contacts, secrecy, and courage. Later she served the Union as a nurse, scout, spy, and leader connected to the Combahee River Raid, which liberated hundreds.²

Tubman's career refuses the separation of mysticism and strategy. Prayer did not replace planning; it steadied action. Her Christianity was not passive submission to providence. It was cooperation with a God understood to desire freedom. This was an exodus faith in which deliverance required people to move at night.

Vigilance and force

Abolitionists disagreed over violence. Garrisonians emphasized nonresistance and moral suasion. Other activists defended rescue by force, especially when slave catchers entered northern communities. In Boston, Syracuse, Christiana, and elsewhere, crowds intervened. Black abolitionists often observed that a society willing to use violence to maintain slavery should not lecture fugitives on peaceful patience.

John Brown and the terror of righteous certainty

John Brown interpreted his struggle against slavery through covenant, judgment, and the example of biblical warriors. After participating in violent conflict in Kansas, he led the 1859 raid on the federal arsenal at Harpers Ferry, hoping to ignite a larger liberation movement. The plan failed; Brown was captured and executed. To some abolitionists he was a martyr. To others his violence threatened both morality and strategy. His story shows the danger and power of sacralizing political action: faith can sustain costly solidarity, but certainty that one acts as God's instrument can also close moral scrutiny.³

"I am now quite certain that the crimes of this guilty land will never be purged away but with blood."

- John Brown, final statement before execution (1859)

The Underground Railroad and Brown's raid occupied different moral worlds, but both exposed the limits of law. Slave law called escape theft and rescue crime. Abolitionist conscience called the law itself a conspiracy against humanity. The Christian doctrine of obedience, once used to discipline the enslaved, was turned against the state: rulers were accountable to a justice higher than statute.

Harriet Tubman

c. 1822-1913

FREEDOM SEEKER,
CONDUCTOR, UNION
SCOUT

CENTRAL IDEA

Divine guidance and disciplined action belonged together; freedom was a calling that created obligations to return for others.

KEY WRITINGS / ACTIONS *Underground Railroad missions; Civil War intelligence and Combahee River operations; postwar advocacy*

Chapter notes and source trail

1. Eric Foner, *Gateway to Freedom: The Hidden History of the Underground Railroad* (W. W. Norton, 2015); Fergus M. Bordewich, *Bound for Canaan* (Amistad, 2005).
2. National Park Service, Harriet Tubman Underground Railroad National Historical Park resources; Kate Clifford Larson, *Bound for the Promised Land: Harriet Tubman, Portrait of an American Hero* (Ballantine, 2004).
3. David S. Reynolds, *John Brown, Abolitionist* (Knopf, 2005); John Brown's final written statement, December 2, 1859.
4. Fugitive Slave Act of 1850; Acts 5:29 was frequently invoked in Christian resistance to unjust law.
5. The chapter distinguishes the organized agency of freedom seekers from romanticized accounts centered solely on white 'conductors.'

CHAPTER 12

Civil War, Judgment, and Emancipation

1861 TO 1865 | From a war for Union to a war that destroyed slavery

The Civil War did not begin as a simple crusade for abolition. It became a war of emancipation because enslaved people, Black abolitionists, soldiers, politicians, and military necessity forced the nation across thresholds it had long avoided.

A war interpreted from the pulpit

Northern and southern clergy both claimed providence. Confederates described slave society as biblically ordered and secession as defense against infidelity and social revolution. Many northern ministers initially emphasized Union, constitutional order, or gradual change. As casualties mounted and enslaved people fled to Union lines, a language of divine judgment grew stronger. The war came to be interpreted as punishment for national complicity in slavery.¹

Self-emancipation changes policy

Enslaved people entered Union camps, withheld labor from Confederates, supplied intelligence, guided troops, and claimed the conflict as an opportunity for freedom. Their movement created the 'contraband' policy and made slavery a military question before federal policy fully embraced abolition. Freedom advanced through footsteps as well as proclamations.²

The Emancipation Proclamation

Lincoln's preliminary proclamation followed the Battle of Antietam; the final Emancipation Proclamation took effect January 1, 1863. It declared enslaved people in areas still in rebellion to be free and authorized Black military service. Its legal scope was limited: it did not immediately free everyone in loyal slave states or already occupied regions. Its political and military significance was enormous. The Union now officially fought against slavery's survival, and Black men could fight in the uniform of the United States.³

Nearly 180,000 Black soldiers served in the Union Army, with additional service in the Navy. Their enlistment made a claim to citizenship through sacrifice while

challenging racist assumptions about courage and capacity. Black chaplains and churches sustained soldiers and refugees. Military emancipation and Christian symbolism converged in watch-night services, prayers, sermons, and songs of Jubilee.

Lincoln's Second Inaugural

On March 4, 1865, Lincoln refused easy claims that God simply favored the Union. Both sides read the same Bible. Both had participated in a national economy shaped by slavery. Lincoln imagined the war as judgment proportionate to 'two hundred and fifty years of unrequited toil.' The speech did not offer a theory of providence that made suffering intelligible. It offered humility: God's purposes could indict the nation using God's name.⁴

"Yet, if God wills that it continue ... until every drop of blood drawn with the lash shall be paid by another drawn with the sword..."

- Abraham Lincoln, Second Inaugural Address (1865)

The Thirteenth Amendment

Congress passed the Thirteenth Amendment in January 1865; the states ratified it in December. It prohibited slavery and involuntary servitude 'except as a punishment for crime.' That exception would later be exploited through convict leasing and racialized criminal law. Legal chattel slavery ended, but the architecture of coerced labor was not completely dismantled.⁵

Christian abolitionists celebrated an answered prayer, but emancipation was not a gift from one president or movement. It was produced by generations of resistance, Black military service, abolitionist agitation, wartime state power, and constitutional change. The war settled the legal question of ownership. It did not settle the meaning of freedom.

**Henry McNeal
Turner**

1834-1915

AME MINISTER, CHAPLAIN,
POLITICIAN

CENTRAL IDEA

Black military service and independent Christian leadership were claims to full citizenship and evidence of providential emancipation.

KEY WRITINGS / ACTIONS *Union Army chaplaincy; Reconstruction politics; AME episcopal leadership; writings on race and nation*

Chapter notes and source trail

1. Mark A. Noll, *The Civil War as a Theological Crisis*; Drew Gilpin Faust, *This Republic of Suffering* (Knopf, 2008).

2. W. E. B. Du Bois called the movement of enslaved people toward Union lines a 'general strike' in *Black Reconstruction in America* (1935); modern scholarship emphasizes self-emancipation.
3. Emancipation Proclamation, January 1, 1863, National Archives; Black military service figures from National Archives and National Park Service materials.
4. Abraham Lincoln, Second Inaugural Address, March 4, 1865.
5. U.S. Constitution, Amendment XIII, ratified December 6, 1865; the punishment exception shaped postwar coerced labor.
6. Steven Hahn, *A Nation Under Our Feet* (Harvard University Press, 2003); Eric Foner, *The Fiery Trial* (W. W. Norton, 2010).

CHAPTER 13

Abolition Beyond the Anglo-American World

NINETEENTH CENTURY | Catholic disputes, Latin American emancipation, Africa, and the limits of imperial humanitarianism

Abolition was a global process without a single Christian pattern. Churches could be allied with slaveholders in one region, antislavery petitioners in another, and both at once within the same communion.

Catholic condemnation and ambiguity

Pope Gregory XVI's *In Supremo Apostolatus* (1839) condemned the slave trade and warned Christians not to reduce people to servitude or defend the traffic. Its language was forceful: the practices were 'absolutely unworthy of the Christian name.' Yet Catholics disagreed over whether the letter condemned all existing slaveholding or primarily new enslavement and trading. In the United States and Brazil, narrow interpretations allowed slaveholding Catholics to claim compliance while the institution endured.¹

This ambiguity reflected a longer pattern. Popes had condemned particular enslavements, especially of Indigenous converts or unjustly captured peoples, while Catholic empires and institutions continued to own enslaved Africans. A moral tradition that distinguished just from unjust slavery could challenge kidnapping but fail to reach hereditary systems already protected by law. The decisive abolitionist claim was that racial chattel slavery was not a lawful relation accidentally abused; its legal powers were themselves unjust.

Latin American paths

Spanish American independence movements produced gradual, uneven emancipation through free-womb laws, military service, manumission, and national decrees. Mexico formally abolished slavery in 1829, though enforcement and local conditions varied. Cuba retained slavery until 1886. Brazil, the largest slave society in the Americas, abolished it only in 1888. Christian actors participated on every side: priests and lay Catholics defended property and order, while others supported manumission, protected fugitives, denounced trafficking, or joined abolitionist societies.²

Brazil's abolitionism included Black brotherhoods, journalists, lawyers, free people of color, escaped slaves, workers, women, and activists such as Luiz Gama, Jose do Patrocinio, Andre Reboucas, Antonio Bento, and Joaquim Nabuco. Some used explicitly Christian arguments; others appealed to liberalism, nation, law, or human rights. The Golden Law of May 13, 1888, was brief and uncompensated, but it offered no land or broad program of economic repair. Former masters lost property claims; freed families inherited inequality.³

Mission, antislavery, and colonial power in Africa

In West Africa, British antislavery and Protestant mission projects helped shape Sierra Leone and Freetown as settlements for Black Loyalists, Jamaican Maroons, recaptives liberated from slave ships, and others. Missionaries educated, translated, and trained African clergy; recaptive communities spread Christianity across the region. Yet humanitarian settlement was entangled with empire. European powers could suppress maritime slave trading while imposing forced labor, political subordination, and cultural domination.⁴

Christian antislavery in Africa therefore had a double edge. Missionaries sometimes sheltered captives and attacked slave raiding; African Christians used mission education to build churches and political movements. But colonial governments appropriated abolitionist language to justify conquest. 'Civilization' could become a new hierarchy. The lesson is not that antislavery was unreal, but that a just cause can be conscripted into unjust power.

The internationalization of abolition

By the late nineteenth century, treaties, naval patrols, missionary societies, international conferences, and national laws had made legal chattel slavery increasingly illegitimate. Enforcement remained selective and often imperial. Debt bondage, forced labor, concubinage, child sale, and domestic slavery survived under new names. Christian abolitionism helped create a universal language of human dignity, but the end of legal recognition did not automatically create freedom on the ground.

Gregory XVI

1765-1846

POPE

CENTRAL IDEA

Christians could not participate in or defend the inhuman traffic in people; the gospel's law of charity judged enslavement and sale.

KEY WRITINGS / ACTIONS *In Supremo Apostolatus* (1839)

Chapter notes and source trail

1. Gregory XVI, In Supremo Apostolatus (1839), English translation at New Advent; Roberto Hofmeister Pich, scholarship on its reception and ambiguity in imperial Brazil.
2. Seymour Drescher, Abolition; George Reid Andrews, Afro-Latin America, 1800-2000 (Oxford University Press, 2004).
3. Angela Alonso, The Last Abolition: The Brazilian Antislavery Movement, 1868-1888 (Cambridge University Press, 2021); Golden Law, May 13, 1888.
4. Suzanne Schwarz, scholarship on Sierra Leone, Protestant Christianity, and abolition; Christopher Fyfe, A History of Sierra Leone (Oxford University Press, 1962).
5. For the danger of imperial self-congratulation, see Catherine Hall and scholarship on humanitarianism and empire.
6. The global chronology varied: abolition statutes did not always end enslavement in practice, and surviving coerced labor systems require local study.

CHAPTER 14

After Emancipation

1865 TO THE PRESENT LEGACY | Reconstruction, racial terror, and freedom unfinished

Abolition destroyed the master's legal title. It did not automatically provide land, safety, education, political power, family restitution, or protection from new forms of coerced labor.

Black churches in Reconstruction

After the Civil War, Black churches expanded at extraordinary speed. Congregations purchased buildings, founded schools, organized conventions, supported political candidates, cared for refugees, solemnized marriages, and reconnected families. Ministers became legislators and public officials. The church was one of the few institutions Black communities controlled at scale. Its sanctuary served as classroom, meeting hall, welfare agency, news network, and political forum.¹

This expansion was liberation and a target. White terrorists attacked Black churches because they understood their political function. Reconstruction's overthrow was accompanied by voter suppression, massacres, labor coercion, and the construction of Jim Crow. Christian symbols appeared on both sides again: Black congregations preached Exodus and citizenship; white supremacists invoked a racialized Christian civilization.

The punishment exception

The Thirteenth Amendment's exception for punishment after conviction enabled states to lease prisoners to private employers. Vagrancy laws and racially discriminatory policing supplied laborers. Convict leasing, debt peonage, sharecropping, contract fraud, and violence reproduced forms of compulsion that observers compared to slavery. The legal name had changed; control of labor and movement could remain brutally constrained.²

Ida B. Wells and the judgment of the church

Ida B. Wells investigated lynching with the evidentiary discipline of earlier abolitionists. She gathered names, accusations, outcomes, and patterns, destroying the mythology that mob violence protected womanhood. Wells repeatedly confronted churches for silence and complicity. Her work extended abolition's

method: testimony plus documentation, moral accusation plus organized pressure. The question was no longer whether people could be legally owned, but whether Black life would be protected by law and Christian conscience.³

From abolition to civil rights

Twentieth-century Black freedom movements inherited abolitionist scripture and institutions. Spirituals, Exodus preaching, prophetic judgment, church boycotts, mass meetings, and nonviolent discipline connected emancipation memory to civil rights. Martin Luther King Jr. spoke from a Black church tradition that treated freedom as both legal status and beloved community. Yet the movement also inherited abolitionism's internal debates: integration or nationalism, nonviolence or self-defense, moral appeal or structural power, reconciliation or reparation.

Modern slavery: continuity and caution

Today, churches and Christian organizations campaign against trafficking, forced labor, debt bondage, child exploitation, and coerced marriage. The phrase 'modern slavery' can mobilize attention, but it must be used carefully. Contemporary abuses differ in law and structure from Atlantic racial chattel slavery. Loose analogy can obscure both histories. The abolitionist inheritance is strongest when it follows money, listens to survivors, challenges state and corporate systems, and refuses rescue stories that make victims passive.⁴

The unfinished work also includes historical truth. Denominations, universities, religious orders, and congregations have begun researching ties to slaveholding, trade, segregation, and racial wealth. Apologies matter when they name specific wrongs. They become credible when joined to archives, memorials, institutional reform, and material repair. Abolitionist repentance was never only a feeling. It was a change in relationship, property, law, and power.

"The way to right wrongs is to turn the light of truth upon them."

- Ida B. Wells, *Crusade for Justice* (autobiographical memoir)

Ida B. Wells

1862-1931

JOURNALIST, ORGANIZER,
ANTI-LYNCHING
CRUSADER

CENTRAL IDEA

Christian civilization could not be judged by its professions while mobs, newspapers, courts, and churches collaborated in racial terror.

KEY WRITINGS / ACTIONS *Southern Horrors* (1892); *A Red Record* (1895); international anti-lynching campaigns

Chapter notes and source trail

1. Eric Foner, *Reconstruction: America's Unfinished Revolution, 1863-1877* (Harper & Row, 1988); Library of Congress Reconstruction resources.
2. Douglas A. Blackmon, *Slavery by Another Name* (Doubleday, 2008); Matthew J. Mancini, *One Dies, Get Another: Convict Leasing in the American South* (University of South Carolina Press, 1996).
3. Ida B. Wells, *Southern Horrors* (1892), *A Red Record* (1895), and *Crusade for Justice*; Crystal N. Feimster, *Southern Horrors* (Harvard University Press, 2009).
4. Joel Quirk, *The Anti-Slavery Project: From the Slave Trade to Human Trafficking* (University of Pennsylvania Press, 2011), on continuities and distinctions.
5. Recent denominational and institutional projects vary in scope; strong work connects confession to documented responsibility and concrete repair.

CHAPTER EPILOGUE

What Christianity Did - and Failed to Do

LOOKING BACKWARD AND FORWARD | A moral accounting

Christian abolitionism was most powerful when it allowed the oppressed neighbor to interpret the tradition, and weakest when institutional self-protection decided in advance what scripture was permitted to mean.

What, then, did Christianity contribute to abolition? It supplied a language of equal creation, Exodus, sin, repentance, providential judgment, neighbor-love, incarnation, and one body in Christ. It supplied congregations, printing networks, schools, missionary correspondence, petitioning habits, disciplined societies, public speakers, hymns, fasts, fundraising, and durable organizations. It gave some activists courage to persist through ridicule, violence, and defeat. It helped turn slavery from a customary institution into a moral emergency.

But Christianity also delayed abolition. Churches taught enslaved people obedience while refusing to teach masters emancipation. Clergy converted biblical description into divine permission. Institutions accepted donations generated by slavery, protected members who owned people, and treated unity as more sacred than justice. Mission sometimes traveled with conquest. Papal and royal documents drew boundaries around the people entitled to liberty. Racial hierarchy learned to speak in the voice of providence.

Why the abolitionists eventually prevailed

They prevailed morally before they prevailed politically because they changed the object of attention. The slaveholder's Bible asked whether ancient masters existed. The abolitionist conscience asked what happened to a child sold from a mother. The slaveholder spoke of order; the fugitive showed scars. The slaveholder claimed property; the abolitionist named kidnapping and stolen labor. The most effective Christian argument was not an ingenious new proof text. It was the joining of scripture to truthful witness.

They also built institutions. Private conviction without organization rarely defeats profitable power. Quaker discipline, Black churches, vigilance committees, antislavery societies, newspapers, lecture circuits, boycotts, petitions, political parties, and military service converted conscience into pressure. Abolitionism

became a movement when people learned how to carry moral knowledge across distance and sustain it through time.

The danger of the redeemed past

Nations and churches often remember abolition more eagerly than slavery. Britain celebrates Wilberforce while forgetting compensation to slaveholders and imperial coercion. American churches celebrate antislavery heroes while minimizing denominational complicity and postwar segregation. Catholic histories may collect papal condemnations without tracing the narrow scope or weak enforcement that allowed slave systems to endure. A truthful inheritance does not choose between pride and shame. It asks what structures made each possible.

The most faithful Christian abolitionists did not claim their tradition had always been innocent. They used its standards to accuse its history. Gregory of Nyssa asked how God's image could be priced. Montesinos asked whether the colonized were not human. Equiano asked nominal Christians what they had learned from their God. Douglass separated Christ from the Christianity that blessed slavery. Lincoln warned both sides against claiming the Almighty. These were acts of internal judgment.

“The history of abolition is not the story of Christianity finally becoming powerful. It is the story of power being forced to answer to the neighbor.”

- Concluding synthesis

That is the enduring lesson. Religious tradition does not become liberating merely by possessing universal ideals. It becomes liberating when communities allow those ideals to judge custom, property, hierarchy, and the institution itself; when people harmed by the system are trusted as interpreters; and when repentance takes political and material form. Abolition was not complete when the law stopped saying 'slave.' It began wherever people refused to let another human being be treated as a thing.

Chapter notes and source trail

1. The synthesis draws especially on David Brion Davis, Seymour Drescher, Christopher Leslie Brown, Manisha Sinha, Albert J. Raboteau, Mark A. Noll, and Katharine Gerbner.
2. For the centrality of Black activism, see Manisha Sinha, *The Slave's Cause*, and Richard S. Newman, *Freedom's Prophet*.
3. For the relationship between Christianity, race, and Protestant slave societies, see Katharine Gerbner, *Christian Slavery: Conversion and Race in the Protestant Atlantic World* (University of Pennsylvania Press, 2018).
4. For public memory and institutional responsibility, consult the primary records of denominations and institutions alongside independent historical scholarship.

CHAPTER APPENDIX A

Chronological Timeline

C. 50-1888 | Key moments in Christian complicity, protest, and abolition

DATE	PLACE / VOICE	SIGNIFICANCE
c. 50-60	Pauline churches	Letters address enslaved believers and masters; Philemon becomes a contested text on brotherhood and bondage.
c. 380	Gregory of Nyssa	Homily on Ecclesiastes attacks the buying of a person made in God's image.
1435	Eugene IV	Sicut Dudum orders the freedom of enslaved Canary Islanders in a specific missionary conflict.
1452-55	Nicholas V	Dum Diversas and Romanus Pontifex grant Portugal conquest privileges including language of perpetual servitude.
1511	Montesinos	Dominican sermon on Hispaniola condemns colonial cruelty and asks whether Indigenous people are not human.
1537	Paul III	Sublimis Deus affirms Indigenous rationality and liberty, though enforcement is weak.
1680s	Mendonca	Lourenco da Silva Mendonca carries a Black Catholic antislavery petition to Rome.
1688	Germantown Friends	First known antislavery protest by a religious body in British North America applies the Golden Rule.
1730s-50s	Lay and Woolman	Quaker dissenters confront slaveholding within their own meetings.
1774	John Wesley	Thoughts upon Slavery declares liberty the right of every human creature.
1777	Prince Hall petition	Black petitioners in Massachusetts invoke natural rights and the religion of Jesus.
1787	Allen and Jones	Black Methodists walk out of segregated worship and build independent institutions.
1789	Olaudah Equiano	The Interesting Narrative joins African testimony, Christian conversion, and abolitionist organizing.
1791-1804	Haitian Revolution	Enslaved people overthrow Saint-Domingue's slave system and establish Haiti.
1807	British Parliament	Britain abolishes its slave trade but not colonial slavery.

DATE	PLACE / VOICE	SIGNIFICANCE
1829	David Walker	Appeal to the Coloured Citizens of the World denounces slavery and white Christian hypocrisy.
1831-32	Sam Sharpe	Jamaican Baptist deacon helps organize a strike and rebellion; colonial repression accelerates emancipation pressure.
1833/1838	British Empire	Slavery Abolition Act begins emancipation; coerced apprenticeship ends in 1838.
1836-37	Grimke and Weld	Christian antislavery writers challenge both slavery and restrictions on women's public action.
1839	Gregory XVI	In Supremo Apostolatus condemns slave trading and enslavement, but its scope is disputed in slave societies.
1844-45	U.S. churches	Methodist and Baptist divisions reveal slavery's power inside national denominations.
1845	Frederick Douglass	Narrative distinguishes the Christianity of Christ from slaveholding religion.
1850	Fugitive Slave Act	Federal law intensifies Christian debate over obedience, rescue, and unjust law.
1852	Stowe / Douglass	Uncle Tom's Cabin reaches a mass audience; Douglass indicts the nation's religious hypocrisy.
1859	John Brown	Harpers Ferry raid brings violent resistance and religious martyrdom into national debate.
1863	United States	Emancipation Proclamation makes destruction of slavery a Union war aim in rebellious territory.
1865	Thirteenth Amendment	Legal slavery ends in the United States, with an exception for punishment after conviction.
1886	Cuba	Slavery ends after gradual legal transition and resistance.
1888	Brazil	Golden Law abolishes slavery in the last major slave society in the Americas.

CHAPTER APPENDIX B

A Guided Library of Primary Writings

SELECTED TEXTS | Where to hear the arguments in the voices of the people who made them

Scripture and early Christianity

- Philemon; Galatians 3; Exodus 1-20; Leviticus 25; Isaiah 58; Luke 4. Read both the passages abolitionists loved and the household codes slaveholders cited.
- Gregory of Nyssa, Homily 4 on Ecclesiastes. The most striking ancient Christian attack on buying a human being.
- Augustine, City of God 19.15. A classic account of slavery as a consequence of sin that nevertheless accepts temporal servitude.

Atlantic conquest and Catholic debate

- Antonio de Montesinos, Advent sermon of 1511, preserved through Las Casas. A direct confrontation with colonial Christians.
- Bartolome de las Casas, A Short Account of the Destruction of the Indies (1552). Essential, but read alongside the history of his early proposal concerning African labor and later regret.
- Paul III, Sublimis Deus (1537); Gregory XVI, In Supremo Apostolatus (1839). Compare strong moral language with legal scope and enforcement.
- Lourenco da Silva Mendonca's seventeenth-century Vatican petition, analyzed and reconstructed by Jose Lingna Nafafe.

Quaker and British abolition

- Germantown Friends' Protest Against Slavery (1688). Very short and ideal for close reading.
- John Woolman, Journal and A Plea for the Poor. A spirituality of complicity, consumption, war, and universal love.
- Anthony Benezet, Some Historical Account of Guinea (1771). Evidence-based attack on racial prejudice and the trade.
- John Wesley, Thoughts upon Slavery (1774). Popular evangelical antislavery in compressed form.
- Olaudah Equiano, The Interesting Narrative (1789). Autobiography, conversion narrative, travel writing, and political intervention.
- Thomas Clarkson, History of the Abolition of the African Slave-Trade (1808). A participant's history of movement organization.

Black American abolition

- David Walker, *Appeal to the Coloured Citizens of the World* (1829). Urgent, biblical, militant, and international.
- Maria W. Stewart, *Productions* (1835). Early Black feminist public theology and political exhortation.
- Henry Highland Garnet, *Address to the Slaves of the United States* (1843). A case for resistance addressed directly to the enslaved.
- Frederick Douglass, *Narrative* (1845), *My Bondage and My Freedom* (1855), and *What to the Slave Is the Fourth of July?* (1852).
- Sojourner Truth, *Narrative of Sojourner Truth* (1850) and the competing reports of her 1851 Akron speech.

The American biblical war

- Angelina Grimke, *Appeal to the Christian Women of the South* (1836). Scripture, gender, and practical action.
- Theodore Dwight Weld, *The Bible Against Slavery* (1837). A systematic abolitionist reading.
- Thornton Stringfellow, *Scriptural and Statistical Views in Favor of Slavery* (1856). A primary proslavery biblical case.
- Benjamin Morgan Palmer, *Thanksgiving Sermon* (1860), and Robert Lewis Dabney, *A Defence of Virginia* (1867). Proslavery providentialism and postwar vindication.
- Harriet Beecher Stowe, *Uncle Tom's Cabin* (1852) and *A Key to Uncle Tom's Cabin* (1853). Fiction joined to documentary proof.
- Abraham Lincoln, *Second Inaugural Address* (1865). A theology of national judgment rather than easy providential self-certainty.

CHAPTER APPENDIX C

Glossary

REFERENCE | Terms that change across time and place

TERM	MEANING IN THIS BOOK
Abolitionism	A movement to end slavery or the slave trade as institutions, not merely to improve treatment. Abolitionists disagreed over immediacy, compensation, political methods, violence, citizenship, and the meaning of freedom.
Apprenticeship	The coerced transitional labor system imposed on many formerly enslaved people in the British Caribbean after the 1833 Act; ended early in 1838 after protest.
Chattel slavery	A system in which law treats people as transferable property. Atlantic chattel slavery became hereditary and racialized, attaching slave status to African descent.
Colonization	Plans to relocate free Black Americans, especially to Africa. Many white antislavery advocates supported colonization; most Black abolitionists condemned it as denial of American belonging.
Encomienda	A Spanish colonial grant of Indigenous labor and tribute, theoretically joined to protection and Christian instruction but often producing severe coercion.
Gradual emancipation	Legal freedom introduced by stages, ages, birth dates, or terms of service. It could make abolition politically possible while forcing generations to remain unfree.
Manumission	The release of an individual enslaved person by an owner or legal process. Manumission can exist within a slave system and is not the same as abolition.
Moral suasion	The strategy of changing public conduct through conscience, testimony, persuasion, exposure of sin, and voluntary withdrawal from complicity.
Proslavery theology	Religious arguments that defended slaveholding as biblically permitted, providentially ordered, socially beneficial, or a mission field for conversion.

TERM	MEANING IN THIS BOOK
Recaptive / Liberated African	A person removed from an intercepted slave ship after legal suppression of the trade, especially in places such as Sierra Leone. Freedom after interception could still involve coerced apprenticeship or colonial control.
Serfdom	A form of inherited agricultural dependence binding people to land and lord. Serfs were not normally saleable in exactly the same way as chattel slaves, though their freedom was heavily constrained.
Slave trade abolition	Prohibition of buying, transporting, or importing enslaved people. It did not by itself free people already held in slavery.
Spiritual equality	The claim that enslaved and free people are equal before God. Historically, churches often affirmed spiritual equality while denying civil and bodily freedom.
Underground Railroad	A decentralized network of self-emancipated people and helpers who supported escape from slavery; not a literal railroad and not controlled by a single organization.

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END

Freedom became thinkable when the person treated as property was heard as a neighbor, a witness, and an interpreter.